Comparison of FTIR elemental carbon (EC) measurements in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia with rural U.S. IMPROVE EC measurements

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Why elemental carbon in Addis Ababa?

- **Elemental carbon (EC)** is the black, soot-like carbon from burning. It warms the climate and harms health.
- **SPARTAN** (Surface PARTiculate mAtter Network, www.spartan-network.org) samples particles onto filters in cities around the world, mostly in the Global South. It measures EC by **FTIR** (below).
- **Addis Ababa**, capital of Ethiopia (about 2,400 m elevation, about 5 million people), has some of the highest EC in SPARTAN. Households cook and heat with wood and charcoal.
- We use 189 Addis filters (Dec 2022 to Sep 2024) across three seasons: **Dry** (Bega, Oct to Feb), **Belg** short rains (Mar to May) and **Kiremt** long rains (Jun to Sep). All 246 Addis filters in the public SPARTAN release give the same result.

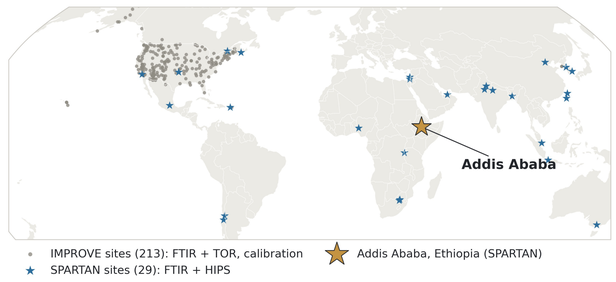


Figure 1. Where the filters come from. Grey: IMPROVE sites (US), which provide the calibration. Blue stars: SPARTAN sites, where the calibration is applied.

How FTIR measures EC: a calibration

FTIR (Fourier-transform infrared spectroscopy) passes infrared light through a Teflon filter and records how much is absorbed at each wavenumber. That curve is the filter's **spectrum**. FTIR is fast, cheap and does not destroy the filter, but a spectrum does not give EC directly: it has to be **calibrated** against a reference.

Most methods are calibrated with laboratory standards. FTIR EC is calibrated with **ambient samples**: real IMPROVE filters on which the same air was collected on a Teflon filter (FTIR spectrum) and on a quartz filter (EC measured by **TOR**, the reference method).

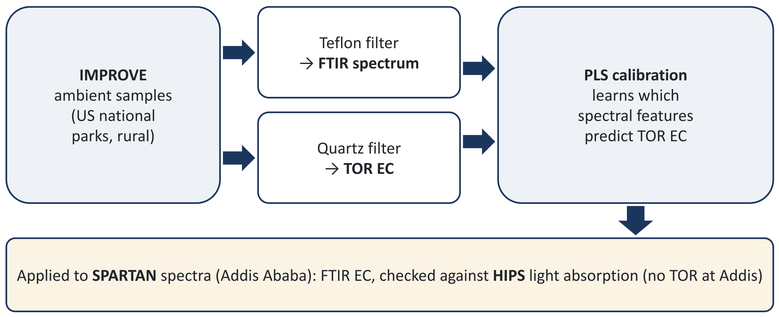


Figure 2. The calibration behind every SPARTAN FTIR EC value.

Why calibrate with IMPROVE filters? Because it is the only data set that exists: no other library of matched Teflon (FTIR) and quartz (TOR) ambient filters exists anywhere, from Addis Ababa or any other city. CSN (the US urban network) filters are bigger and thicker and sample at a lower flow, so FTIR calibrations built on them predict less well.

Key terms

IMPROVE: Interagency Monitoring of PROtected Visual Environments, the US network sampling in national parks and rural areas (vista.cira.colostate.edu/Improve).

TOR: thermal-optical reflectance. Heats a punch of a quartz filter and measures the carbon released; the standard reference for EC.

HIPS: hybrid integrating plate/sphere. Measures how much red light (633 nm) a Teflon filter absorbs, called **Fabs**.

MAC: mass absorption cross-section, the light absorbed per gram of EC (m^2/g). EC = Fabs / MAC. We use MAC = 10 m^2/g, a common default; the true value varies with sources. Changing MAC changes the slope in Figure 4, not the intercept, so MAC alone cannot fix Addis.

Calibration set: the IMPROVE filters (with TOR EC) that one calibration is built from.

PLS: partial least squares regression, which turns a whole spectrum into one number (EC).

Baseline correction of the spectra: removing the smooth background from the Teflon filter and light scattering, so only particle absorption remains.

Deming regression: a straight-line fit that allows for error in both measurements. Agreement means slope 1, intercept 0.

Acknowledgments: supported by the NASA MAIA mission. Thanks to the SPARTAN team and the UC Davis FTIR group.

Addis Ababa EC is high, and so is its share of PM2.5

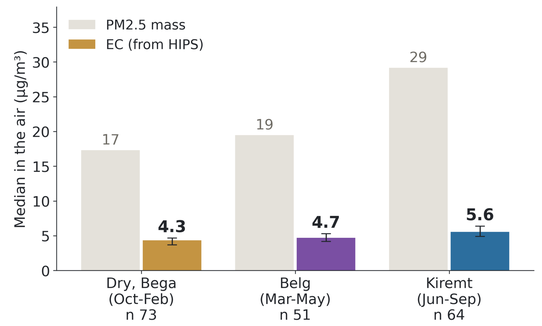


Figure 3. Addis medians by season (bars on EC: interquartile range). EC is 4.3 to 5.6 µg/m³ and 19 to 25% of PM2.5 in every season, against about 4% for a typical IMPROVE filter.

The problem: FTIR EC is poorly predicted but well correlated

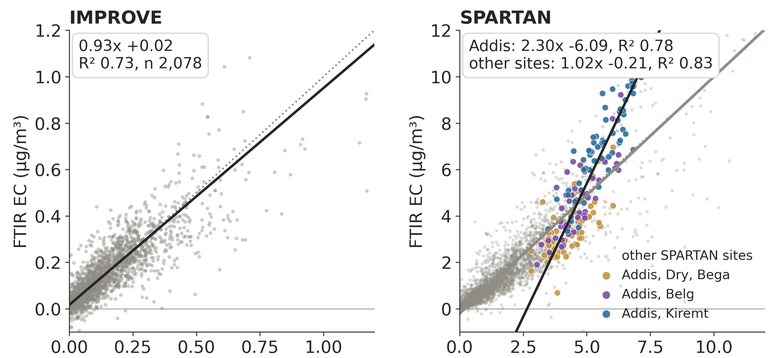


Figure 4. Each point is one filter; dotted line: 1:1. **IMPROVE:** 2,078 filters, FTIR against TOR EC: slope near 1, intercept near 0. **SPARTAN:** FTIR against HIPS EC. The other SPARTAN sites together are predicted reasonably (grey line), and Addis sits inside that cloud, but Addis alone is well correlated with the wrong slope and intercept (2.3x -6.1). Every season is off (slopes 1.4 to 2.2).

IMPROVE filters that look like Addis fail too

From the IMPROVE filters we picked the 97 whose **spectra most resemble the Addis spectra**. Many are smoke-affected.

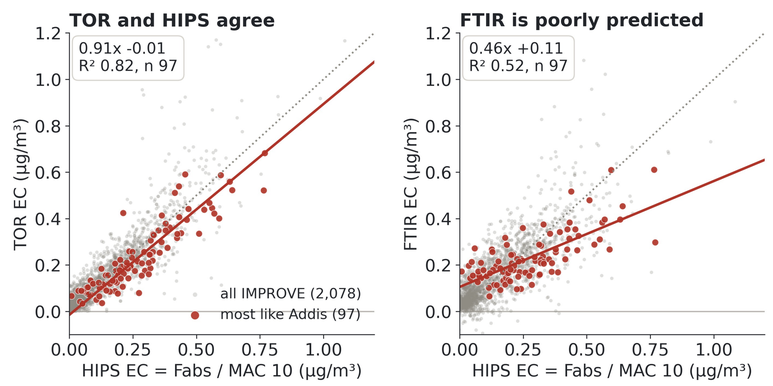


Figure 5. Grey: all IMPROVE filters; red: the 97 most like Addis. TOR and HIPS agree on them, but the same FTIR calibration predicts them poorly, at ordinary IMPROVE concentrations. Same calibration; only the samples changed.

Addis filters carry far more EC than IMPROVE filters

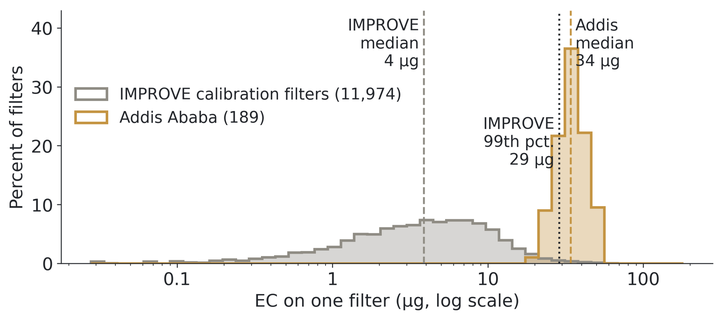


Figure 6. EC on one filter, from each filter's own volume of air (flow × sampling time). The typical Addis filter carries about 9× the EC of a typical IMPROVE calibration filter, and 79% are above the IMPROVE 99th percentile.

Toward a better calibration (work in progress)

Step 1. Baseline correction of the spectra, the biggest gain so far.

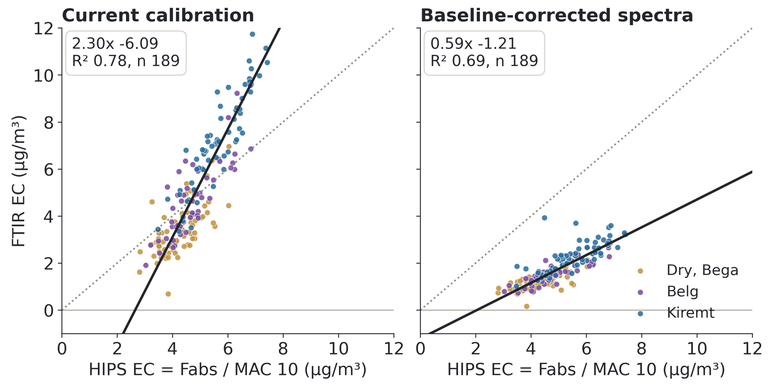


Figure 7. Same Addis filters, same axes as Figure 4. Correcting the baseline moves the intercept from -6.1 to -1.2 µg/m³, but the slope drops to 0.59.

Step 2. Test thousands of calibrations with an interactive app we built, changing which IMPROVE filters are in the calibration set and how it is built.

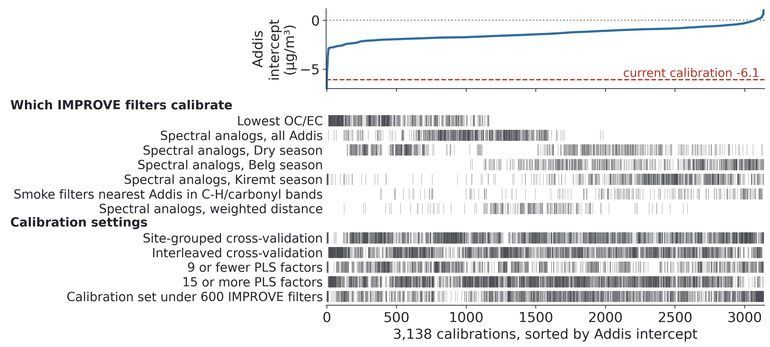


Figure 8. Each column is one calibration (3,138, all on baseline-corrected spectra), sorted by its Addis intercept (top). Tick marks show which choices it used. 254 put the intercept within ±0.5 µg/m³ of zero; 20 of those also have a slope between 0.8 and 1.25. Next: find out why those work, or whether it is chance.

Step 3. One calibration per season, built from the IMPROVE filters whose spectra most resemble that season's Addis spectra.

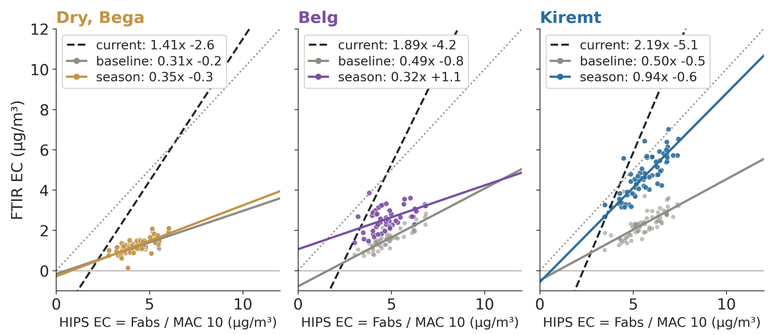


Figure 9. Dashed: current calibration; grey: baseline-corrected (Step 1); colour: season-specific. Kiremt improves (slope 0.50 to 0.94); Dry and Belg do not yet.

Conclusions and next steps

- FTIR EC calibrated on ambient IMPROVE filters predicts IMPROVE, and the SPARTAN network as a whole, reasonably, but not Addis Ababa.
- Concentration is not the whole story: IMPROVE filters with Addis-like spectra are poorly predicted at ordinary IMPROVE levels. Addis burns different fuels (wood, charcoal) from rural US sites, so its EC may differ in composition.
- Next: choose calibration filters by EC-to-PM2.5 ratio; check TOR on the heaviest smoke-affected IMPROVE filters; longer term, collocated Teflon and quartz filters in Addis Ababa.

References

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Data: SPARTAN public release v3.1.4 (www.spartan-network.org/data); IMPROVE data from the Federal Land Manager Environmental Database (FED, views.cira.colostate.edu/fed).